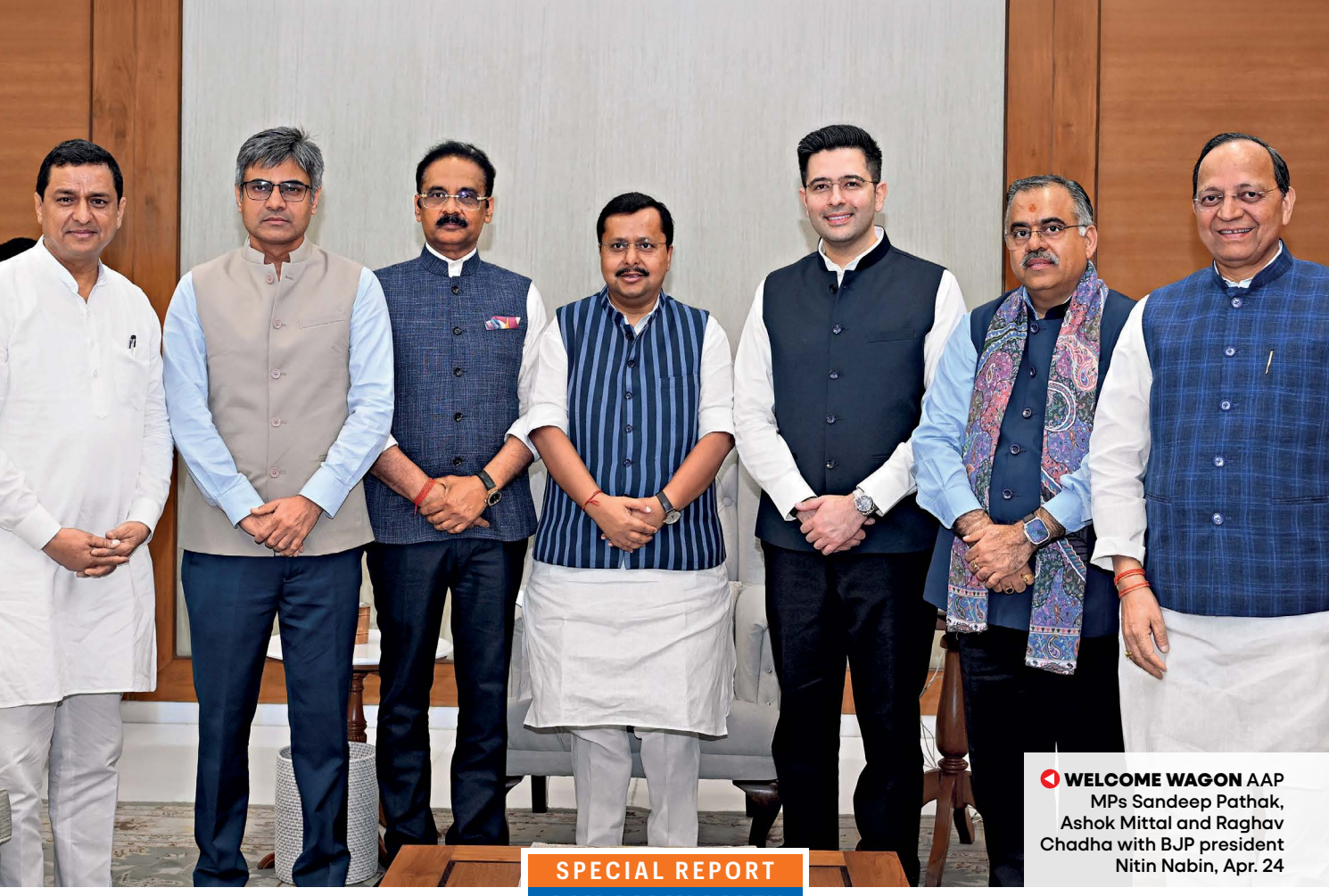


WELCOME WAGON AAP MPs Sandeep Pathak, Ashok Mittal and Raghav Chadha with BJP president Nitin Nabin, Apr. 24

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SPECIAL REPORT
AAM AADMI PARTY

AAP UNDER SIEGE

The defection of its Rajya Sabha MPs—and former close aides—throws AAP off balance ahead of the battle for Punjab next year

By ANILESH S. MAHAJAN and AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR

The election churn was in Bengal and elsewhere, but that didn't stop the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) from doing a surgical strike on the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in the capital. On April 24, seven of the latter's 10 Rajya Sabha MPs—six from Punjab and one from Delhi—crossed over to the saffron side. They include AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal's proteges Raghav Chadha and Sandeep Pathak, businessmen Ashok Mittal, Vikramjit Singh Sahney and Rajinder Gupta, cricketer Harbhajan Singh as well as activist-politician Swati Maliwal (from Delhi).

The numbers alter the balance in the Upper House. Splitting over two-thirds of its parent legislative unit, Chadha's faction beat the disqualification clause under the anti-defection provisions. The BJP now controls six of Punjab's seven Rajya Sabha seats—in a state where they managed just two MLAs (out of the total 117) in the 2022 assembly election. Its Rajya Sabha tally moves to 113, just 10 short of a simple majority on its own. The NDA moves up to 149 in the 245-MP House. AAP is now reduced to six MPs—three in the Lok Sabha, and its rump unit in the RS.

An inkling of what lay ahead came on April 5, when the AAP leadership removed Chadha as the party's deputy leader in the Rajya Sabha, replacing him with Ashok Mittal. Rumours that a disaffected Chadha—one of AAP's most recognisable faces—might jump ship had been circling for months now. The surprise was in the kind of coup he would engineer. Sanjay Singh, AAP's leader in the House, posted on